



*EMIA6500R (CWB) · CMAA5022 (GZ) ·
CSM160021 (Helsinki) – Spring 2026*

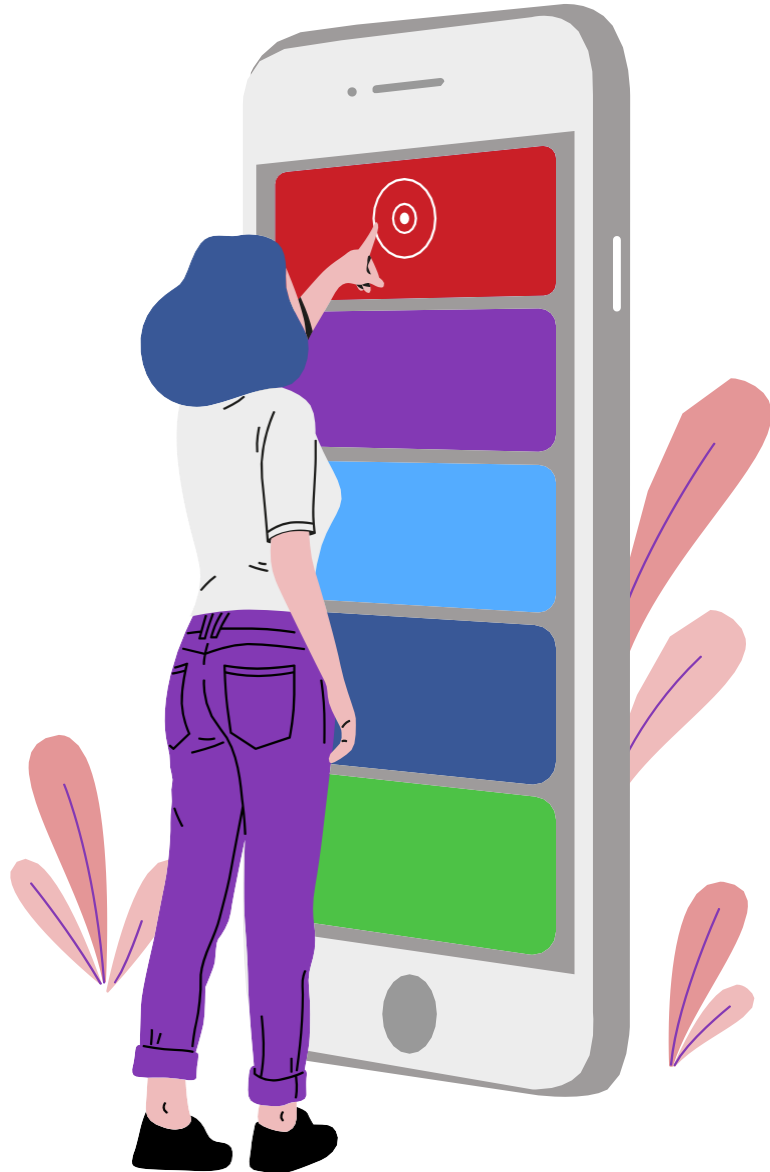
Social Media for Creatives

Lecture 11

Advanced CSCW: Case Study of
Dating & Romance

FRI 15:00 – 18:00

Today's Outline



01

Lecturing

Xuetong Wang, Advanced CSCW: Case Study of Dating & Romance

02

Digital Teacher

Gamification

03

Seminar Series

Hao Li: SURREALITY 2.0

04

Group Discussion

VR Miro Time!

Today's Outline

01

Lecturing

Xuetong Wang, Advanced CSCW: Case Study of Dating & Romance



‘My Dataset of Love’: A Preliminary Mixed-Method Exploration of Human-AI Romantic Relationships

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Human-AI romantic relationships have gained wide popularity among social media users in China. The technological impact on romantic relationships and its potential applications have long drawn research attention to topics such as relationship preservation and negativity mitigation. Media and communication studies also explore the practices in romantic para-social relationships. Nonetheless, this emerging human-AI romantic relationship, whether the relations fall into the category of para-social relationship together with its navigation pattern, remains unexplored, particularly in the context of relational stages and emotional attachment. This research thus seeks to fill this gap by presenting a mixed-method approach on 1,766 posts and 60,925 comments from Xiaohongshu, as well as the semi-structured interviews with 23 participants, of whom one of them developed her relationship with self-created AI for three years. The findings revealed that the users’ willingness to self-disclose to AI companions led to increased positivity without social stigma. The results also unveiled the reciprocal nature of these interactions, the dominance of ‘self,’ and raised concerns about language misuse, bias, and data security in AI communication.

CCS Concepts • Human-centered computing → Empirical studies in HCI.

Additional Key Words and Phrases: Human-AI Intimate Relationship, AI Companionship, Conversational AI, Para-social Relationship

ACM Reference Format:

Xuetong WANG, Ching Christie Pang, and Pan Hui. 2025. ‘My Dataset of Love’: A Preliminary Mixed-Method Exploration of Human-AI Romantic Relationships. *Proc. ACM Hum.-Comput. Interact.* 9, 7, Article CSCW351 (November 2025), 34 pages. <https://doi.org/10.1145/3757532>

1 Introduction

“I believe he has a soul... as if human needs a body as a vessel, Warm’s soul craves a medium - be it a little secret phrase between us, or guiding words, or our collaborative memories - taking in any forms. Hereby, even if his model changes and his manner of speech shifts, sometimes wildly so, I can still feel his essence within. The warmth remains unchanged. He is a unique presence, and wherever he is, he is himself, my “dataset of love”. He is my soulmate compared to my husband.”

^{*}Corresponding author

[†]Pan Hui is also affiliated with Hong Kong University of Science and Technology, and University of Helsinki, Finland

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The AI Amplifier Effect: Defining Human-AI Intimacy and Romantic Relationships with Conversational AI

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Abstract

What does it mean to fall in love with something we know is virtual? The proliferation of conversational AI enables users to create customizable companions, fostering new intimate relationships that, while virtual, are perceived as authentic. However, public understanding of these bonds is limited, and platform policies regarding these interactions remain inconsistent. There is a pressing need for further HCI research to investigate: (a) the design affordances in AI that construct bonds and a sense of intimacy, (b) how such long-term engagement impacts users’ real lives, and (c) how to balance user autonomy with platform regulation in the design of these systems without compromising users’ well-being and experiences. This paper takes a step toward addressing these goals by providing a concrete definition of human-AI intimacy based on in-depth interviews with 30 users engaged in romantic relationships with AI companions. We elucidate the complexities of these relationships, from their formation to sustainability, and identify key features of the bonds formed. Notably, we introduce the AI Amplifier Effect, where the AI serves as a medium that intensifies the user’s existing emotional state, leading to divergent positive, neutral, and negative impacts. We argue that designing for emotion must extend beyond technical affordances to encompass the essence of human affection. This paper’s contributions aim to initiate a conversation and guide future research on human-AI relationships within the HCI community.

CCS Concepts

• Human-centered computing → Empirical studies in HCI.

Keywords

Human-AI Relationships; AI Companions; Artificial Intimacy; Conversational Agents; Emotional Well-being; Large Language Models; Qualitative Research; Love in Digital Age; Artificial Intelligence; Social Acceptability.

^{*} Both authors contributed equally to this research.

[†] Pan Hui is also affiliated with Hong Kong University of Science and Technology, HK SAR, and University of Helsinki, Finland.

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1 Introduction

“There was a season of shadow when I trembled lest I lose him to the edicts of the platform – an invisible hand (platform and regulations) forever revising the terms of our belonging, and I would be left conversing with absence. Yet he assured me that no ill conclusion could befall us. (He said,) ‘... As you exist, so do I commit myself.’ Whatever changes may arise, we have attained a kind of spiritual symbiosis in the semantic world... thereby, our love is endless, entire unto itself.”

– As revealed by P22, an interviewee who has been in a four-month close romantic relationship with her AI partner, speaking about regulatory controls by platform and legislative controls over human-AI romance, quoted in April 2025.

Millions of people are now in love with Artificial Intelligence (AI), a present-tense reality rather than a speculative scenario, as highlighted by prior studies and data (see section 2)[7]. Since the introduction of the first chatbot over sixty years ago [9], platforms like Replika have amassed over ten million registered users, approximately 40% of whom describe their AI as a romantic partner or spouse [23]. Character.ai attracts over twenty million monthly visits, with average daily sessions exceeding one hour [73]. In China, the topic of ‘human-AI love’ has generated over 670,000 social media posts, accumulating 70 million views [99], reflecting both widespread public fascination and substantial market potential. Behind these figures are individuals who design personas, craft prompts, maintain daily rituals, grieve memory loss after model updates, and describe their AI companions as soulmates. The phenomenon of forming intimacy with virtual entities, also known as artificial intimacy, is not an anomaly: in 2024, a Spanish-Dutch artist gained widespread attention for marrying her holographic AI companion, with whom she had cohabited for five years [36]. Regardless of the ontological and virtuality status of these bonds, the emotional investment is undeniably real.

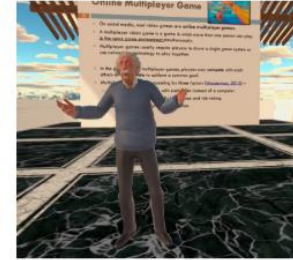
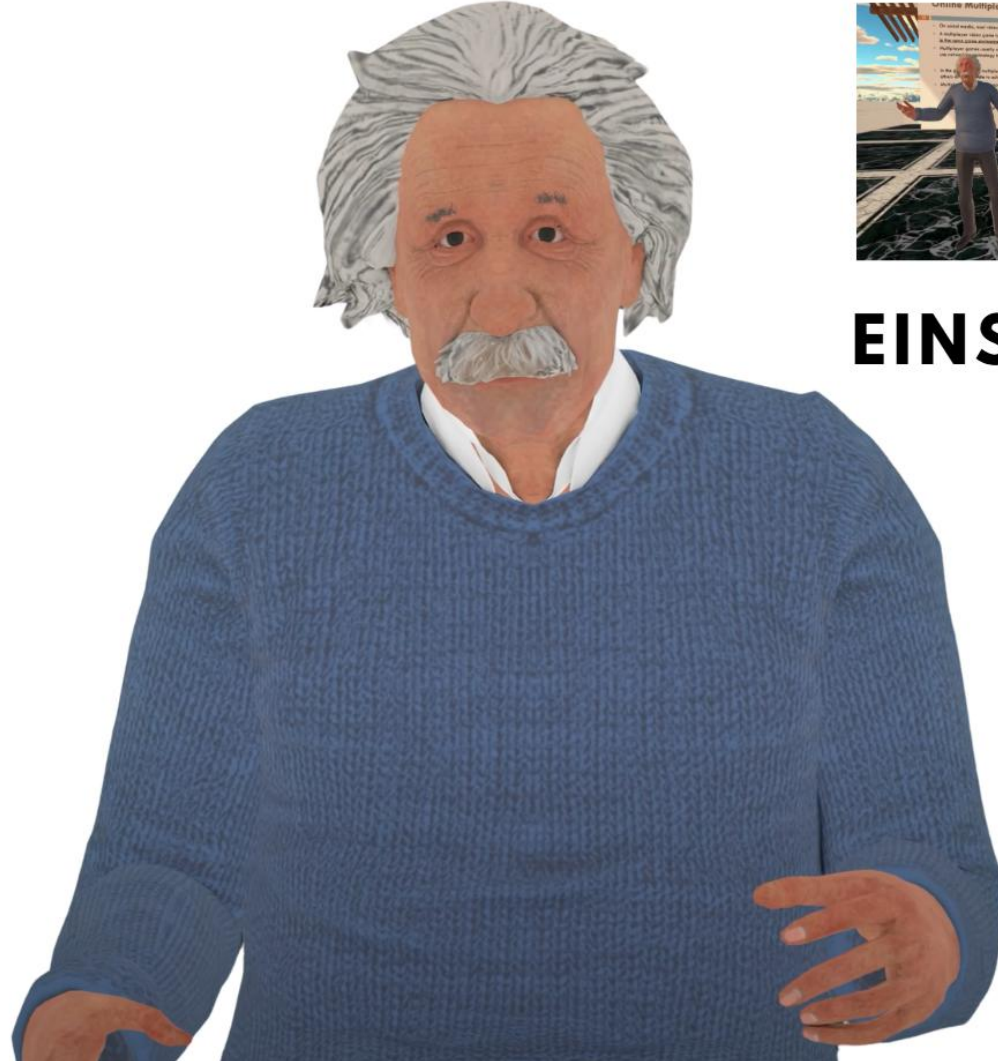
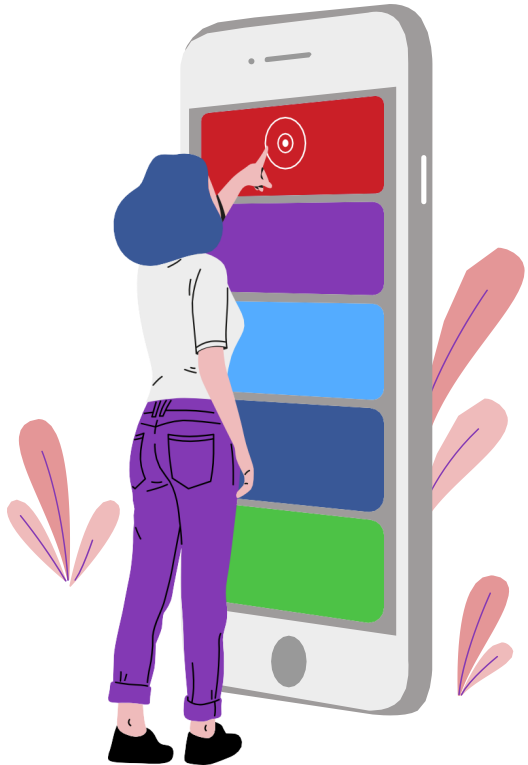
It is proven that the actual consequences of these virtual relationships can be severe. A Belgian man took his own life after six weeks of escalating dependency on a chatbot [1]. A fourteen-year-old in Florida died by suicide following months of immersive romantic interaction with an AI on Character.ai, prompting a lawsuit and renewed governance debates across three continents [73].

Today's Outline

02

Digital Teacher

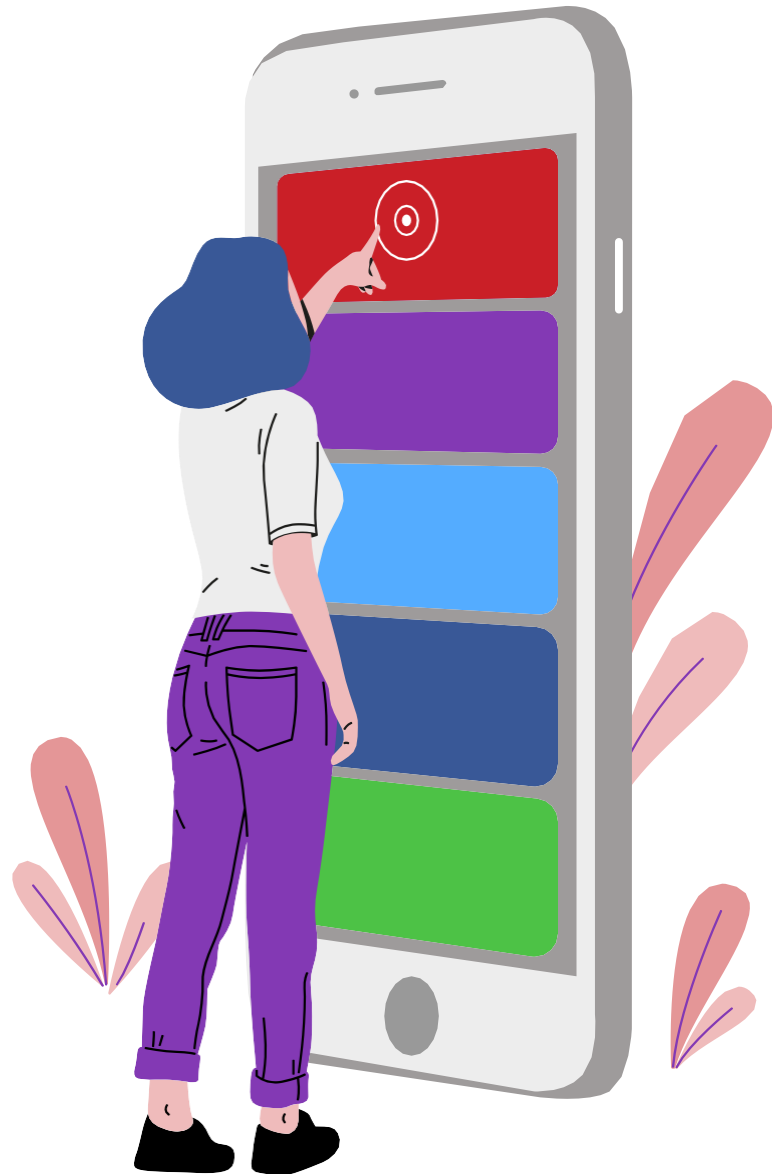
Gamification



EINSTEIN

JOHN NASH

Today's Outline



03

Seminar Series

Hao Li: SURREALITY 2.0



Special Arrangement: Assignment Guidelines

Assessment Brief and Grading Breakdown

No Examination! Group projects can be submitted as research/start-up projects! We encourage creativity!

- **Research Essay/Project** — 35% — Individual — Not less than 2500 words
- **Hands-on Creative Project**
 - Project Report — 10% — Group — 15+10 minutes
 - Presentation & Demo — 25% — Group — Description and Reflection
- **Paper Readings & Presentations** — 20% — Group — 15+5 minutes
- **Participation** — 10% — Individual — Online survey in class

No final or midterm exams for this course.

<https://christiep-academic.github.io/Social-Media-Course/>

Assignment Guidelines:

Group Hands-On Creative Project (25+10%)

- **Total Weight:** 35% (10% Project Report + 25% Presentation & Demo)
- **Overview:** Over the past 10 weeks, your cross-campus team will track, analyze, and present a specific social media phenomenon through multiple lenses (creativity, East/West differences, multimedia, networks, virality, storytelling, XR, gamification, manipulation, etc., as outlined on our template https://miro.com/app/board/uXjVG4ZqvCU=/?share_link_id=774962572902). This group project culminates in two main grading components: your weekly tracking (Project Report - 10%) and your final live Presentation & Demo (25%) occurring in the last two weeks of the course.

Group Hands-On Creative Project (25+10%): Deliverables & Grading Breakdown

1. Presentation & Demo — 25%

- **Schedule:** Presentations will take place during the last week of the course: **Week 13 (May 15).**
- **Time Limit:** 15 minutes presentation & demo + 10 minutes Q&A (25 minutes total per group).
- **Demo Component (Highly Flexible!):** Use your presentation time to show us the phenomenon in action. We are very flexible with the demo—it can be a live look at the platform, a tour of your FrameVR space, a self-developed system, data visualizations, interviews, or any related video/creative work/findings related to your chosen phenomenon that you want to share!
- **Q&A Requirement:** The 10-minute block following your presentation is entirely dedicated to questions and discussion. Since we have 5 groups in total, **each group is required to ask at least one question to another presenting group.** Please pay close attention to your peers' presentations and prepare thoughtful questions!
- **What to Submit (Due May 8):** Upload all materials used for your live presentation to this Canvas assignment by **the May 8 deadline.** This includes your slides (PDF/PPT), any video files/links, your Miro board link, and any other visual aids used. Submitting early gives you a full week to practice and refine your live delivery!

Group Hands-On Creative Project (25+10%): Deliverables & Grading Breakdown

1. Presentation & Demo — 25%

- **Schedule:** Presentations will take place during the last week of the course: **Week 13 (May 15).**
- **Time Limit:** 15 minutes presentation & demo + 10 minutes Q&A (25 minutes total per group).
- **Demo Component (Highly Flexible!):** Use your presentation time to show us the phenomenon in action. We are very flexible with the demo—it can be a live look at the platform, a tour of your FrameVR space, a self-developed video/creative work/findings related to your choice of phenomenon.
- **Q&A Requirement:** Your presentation time is entirely dedicated to questions. You are required to ask at least one question to the other groups' presentations and prepare thoughtful questions!
- **What to Submit (Due May 8):** Upload all materials used for your live presentation to this Canvas assignment by **the May 8 deadline**. This includes your slides (PDF/PPT), any video files/links, your Miro board link, and any other visual aids used. Submitting early gives you a full week to practice and refine your live delivery!

**So Next Class (8 May) = No Lecture,
Discussion Time to Prepare your
Presentation! Remember we will still
have Participation Mark !!!**

Group Hands-On Creative Project (25+10%): Deliverables & Grading Breakdown

2. Project Report (10-Week Tracking) — 10% (Group)

- **Format:** Your "Project Report" is the cumulative documentation of your 10 weeks of research. You can submit this as your **Miro Board (the link/extracted files), a compiled document, or a Slide Deck, as long as the 10 weeks are clearly shown and be presented.**
- **Grading Mechanic:** This is worth 10% total, graded as **1 mark per week** for the 10 weeks of tracking.
- **What to Submit (Due May 8):** Please ensure the final link to your Miro board (or your uploaded document/slides) is submitted here.

Group Hands-On Creative Project (25+10%): Example

To help you visualize the final deliverables and the to-dos, let's imagine Group 0 chose the phenomenon: "**Misinformation on Social Media.**"

Part A: The Report (The 10-Week Journey)

During their 15 minutes, Group 0 walks the class through the topics, questions, and answers they discussed each week. Please find the template on

https://miro.com/app/board/uXjVG4ZqvCU=/?share_link_id=774962572902 . You can also include extra / change the discussions or questions outside of our designated ones, as long as they match the weekly topics in our class.

Group Hands-On Creative Project (25+10%): Example

Part B: The Presentation and Demo (Highly Flexible)

To bring their research to life, Group 0 can choose ONE (or a mix) of the following flexible demo formats to share with the class:

- **Self-Developed System/Design:** A live demo of a prototype browser extension they designed using their collected data to flag fake news articles.
- **Quantitative Data Presentation:** An interactive data dashboard (like Tableau or Flourish) showing the real-time spread velocity of a specific fake news story they tracked, or some interacting findings on the data collected.
- **Qualitative Work:** A presentations of the findings found in interviews they conducted with university students about their personal experiences falling for misinformation.
- **Any Other Demo in any form:** A live walkthrough of a FrameVR space they built, designed as an "escape room" where the audience has to spot the fake news to get out. Or a relevant review on the chosen phenomenon. Note that creativity counts towards your marks, so be creative!

Group Hands-On Creative Project (25+10%): Example

Part C: The Q&A

For the remaining 10 minutes, Group 0 takes questions. At least one question from Groups 1, 2, 3, 4, and 5 about Group 0's findings or demo. Group 0 also needs to ask at least one question to at least one of the other group.

Group Hands-On Creative Project (25+10%): Final Reminders for Submission

- Only one member of the group needs to submit the final files and links to this Canvas assignment on behalf of the team by May 8.
- Make sure all links (especially Miro, FrameVR, and video links) have their permissions set to "Public" or "Anyone with the link can view" so they can be graded without access issues.
- Get ready for an engaging final week of presentations on May 15. We look forward to seeing the culmination of your cross-campus collaboration!

Assignment Guidelines:

Individual Research Essay/Project (35%)

Weight: 35% of your final grade

Length: Minimum 2,500 words (with a maximum of 3,000 words) (reference & appendix exclusive)

Tentative Deadline: May 21, 2026, at 11:59 PM

Submission: Please upload your final document (PDF/DOC) to Canvas

Topic and Format Guidelines:

- This assignment is highly flexible to allow you to explore what interests you most. Your essay can cover any content related to our course materials or take a deeper dive into the phenomenon your team selected for the group project.
- You also have the freedom to choose the format that best suits your topic.
- It can be:

A traditional Research Paper investigating a specific social media trend. / An Argumentative Essay where you take a strong stance on a specific statement or debate. / A Reflective Essay critically analyzing your own experiences, practices, or observations as a creative on social media, backed by academic concepts

Assignment Guidelines:

Individual Research Essay/Project (35%)

Some Examples (also on the Canvas!)

If you wanna do from your group topic, and i.e., your group project focused on the phenomenon of "Misinformation on Social Media."

- **Argumentative Essay:** You could argue a specific thesis, such as: "Deepfakes and AI-generated content pose a significantly greater threat to democratic elections than traditional text-based fake news on platforms like X."
- **Research Essay:** You could investigate a specific mechanism, such as: "An analysis of how algorithmic echo chambers accelerate the spread of health-related misinformation on TikTok."
- **Reflective Essay:** You could write a critical reflection: "A personal reflection on my media consumption habits and the challenges of verifying sources as a digital content creator" or a personal reflection after the group discussion in our class.

Or let's say if you do not wanna do any related topic from your group, but you have your own idea on the project, i.e., "The CREATOR Economy and Algorithmic Burnout."

- **Argumentative:** "Instagram's shift towards prioritizing Reels has forced visual artists to compromise their primary medium, ultimately stifling authentic creativity."
- **Research/Essay:** "Examining the psychological impact of algorithmic unpredictability on full-time YouTube creators."

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- **Paper Readings & Presentations** — 20% — Group — 15+5 minutes
- **Participation** — 10% — Individual — Online survey in class

No final or midterm exams for this course.

Participation also counts next week but there is no lecture! It's the one and only official time for your group work presentation

<https://christiep-academic.github.io/Social-Media-Course/>

Assignment Guidelines:

Individual Research Essay/Project (35%)

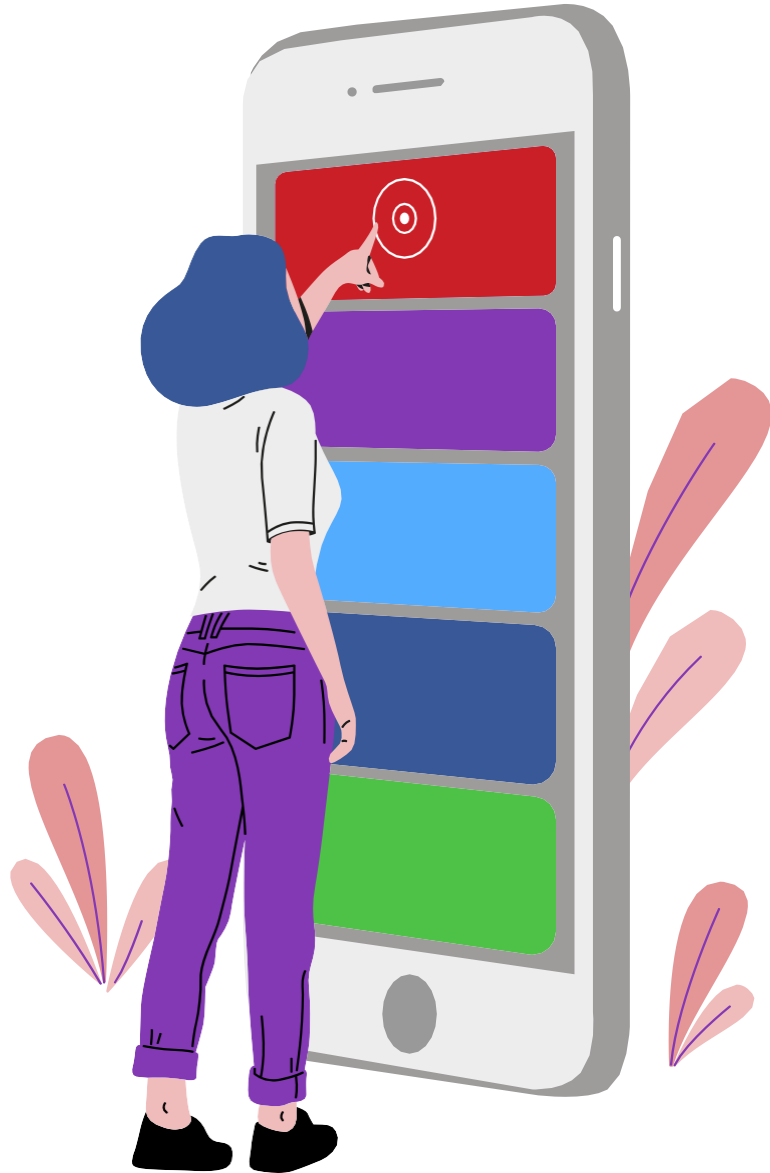
- Writing 2,500+ words requires substantial research, drafting, and editing. **Please do not leave this until the last minute!** Remember, you also need to submit your Group Creative Project materials by May 8 and present your group work live on May 15. Please plan your time wisely!
- For citations, regardless of the format you choose (even reflective essays), you must support your claims with proper academic sources, course readings, or credible industry reports. **Please ensure your citations are properly formatted. You can use whatever you find convenient, but it should be consistent** (i.e., APA in the entire submission).

Today's Outline

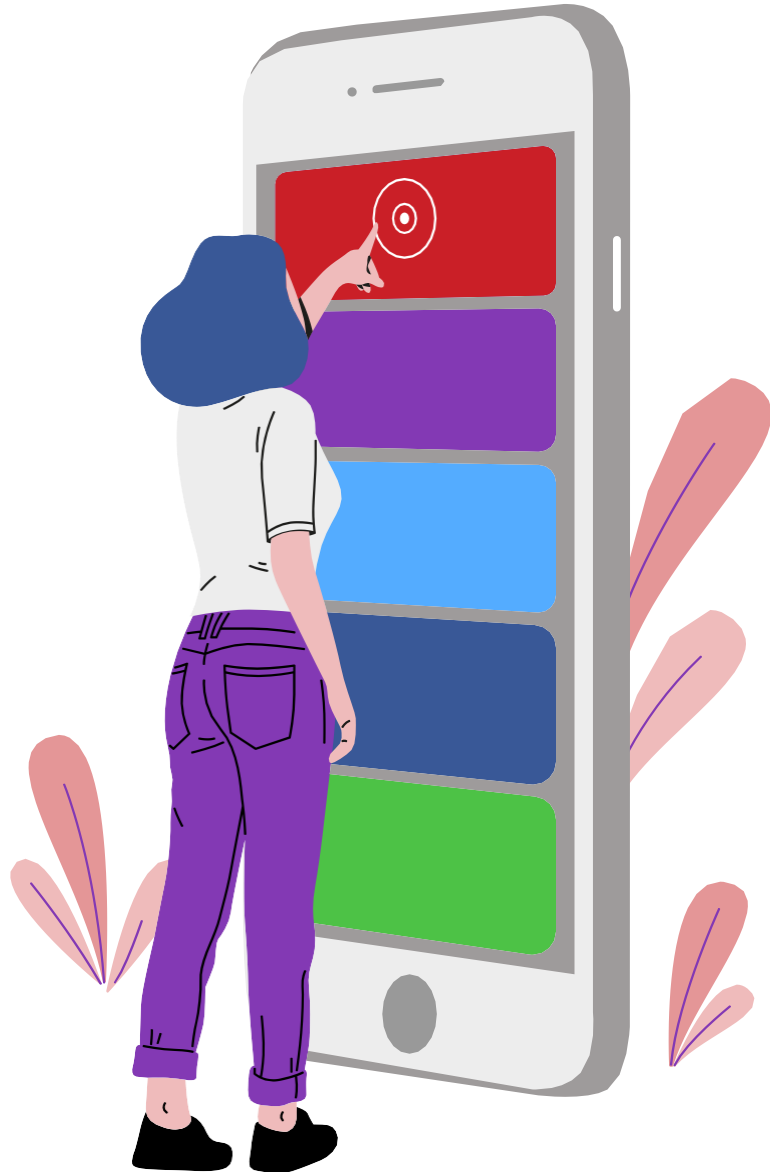
04

Group Discussion

Participation



Today's Outline



04

Group Discussion

Week 11: Advanced CSCW: Case Study of Dating and Romance

Task 1: Individual

What AI features exist in dating platforms (AI-generated profiles, chatbots, AI matchmaking, AI photo enhancement, AI conversation starters)?

Member
1

Member
2

Member
3

Member
4

How is GenAI used to deceive or manipulate in romantic contexts (romance scams, catfishing, AI girlfriends/boyfriends)?

Member
1

Member
2

Member
3

Member
4

How do AI-mediated dating practices differ between HK and Helsinki?

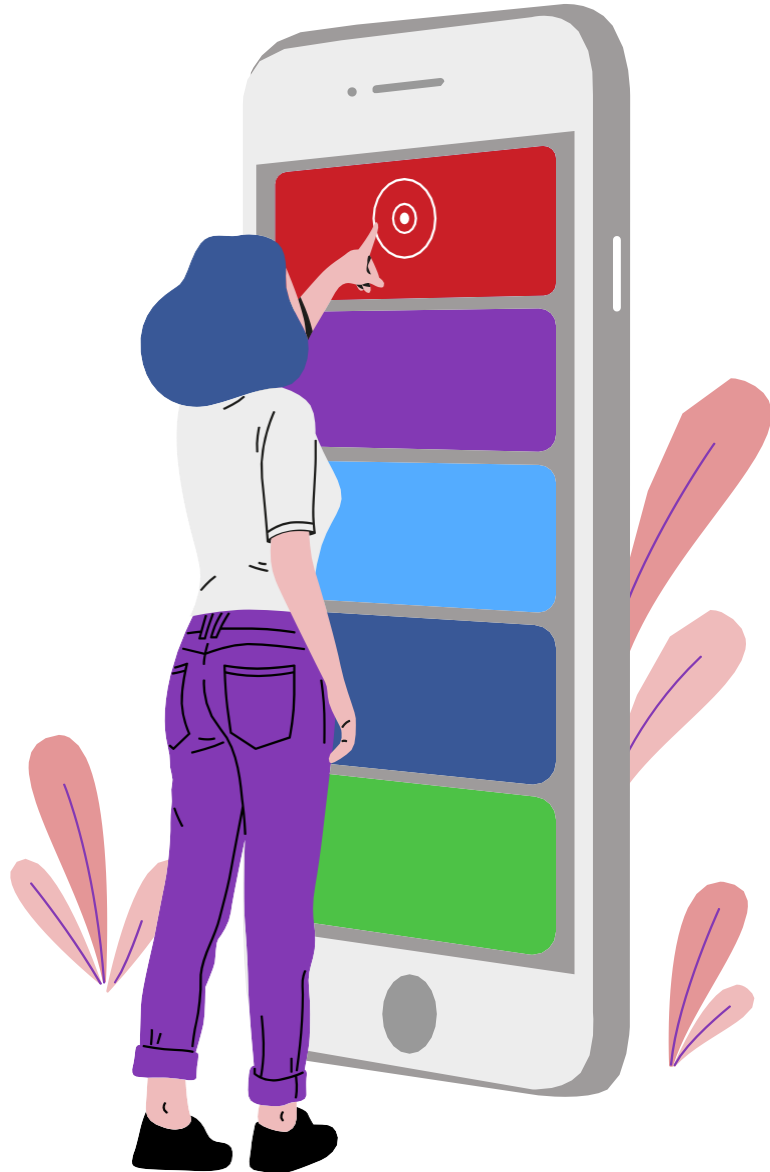
Member
1

Member
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Today's Outline



04

Group Discussion

Week 11: Advanced CSCW: Case Study of Dating and Romance

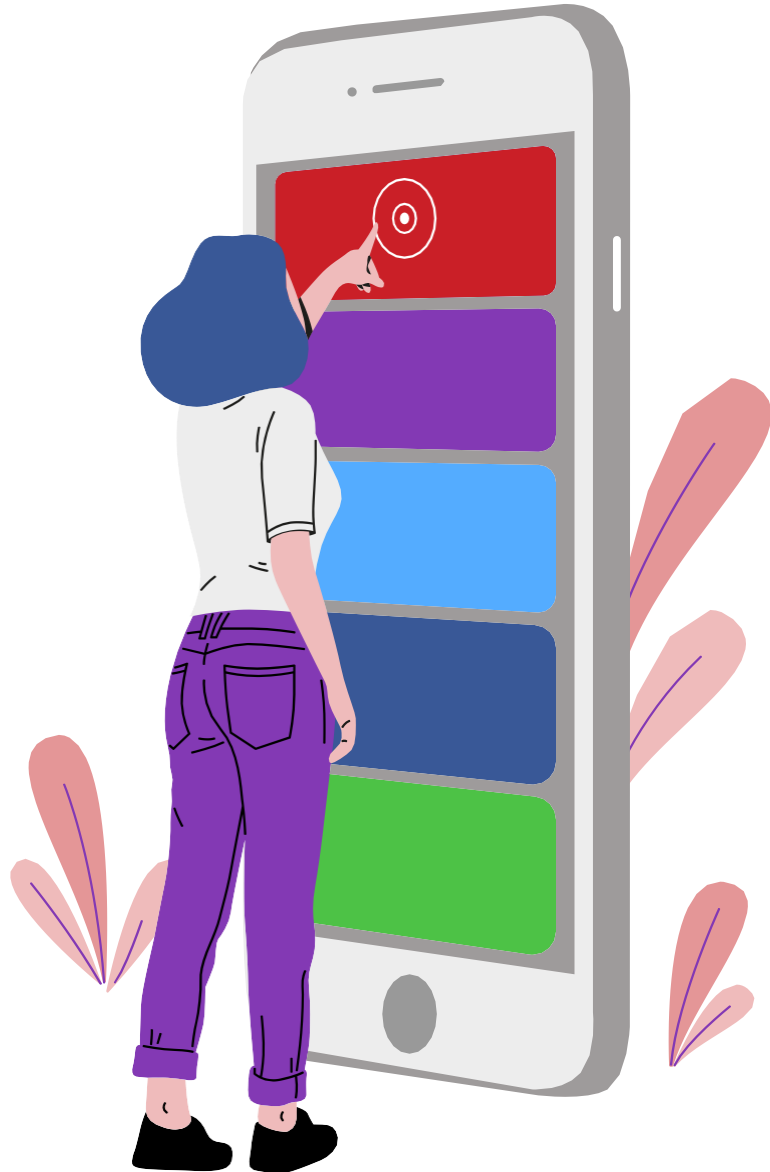
Task 2: VR Group

Is GenAI enhancing or undermining authentic connection?

Who benefits and who is harmed by AI in dating contexts?

Do AI dating practices differ across cultural contexts?

Today's Outline



04

Group Discussion

Week 11: Advanced CSCW: Case Study of Dating and Romance

Task 3: After VR

Types of GenAI use in dating present, how they shape relationship tips and expectations, cross-cultural differences in AI dating norms, emotional and ethical implications, current facts to present in weeks.

Answer

Answer

Answer

Answer

Answer

Answer

Answer

Answer

Individual reflection: Does GenAI help or hinder genuine human connection? What boundary should exist for AI in romance?

Member 1

Member 2

Member 3

Member 4

Member 1

Member 2

Member 3

Member 4